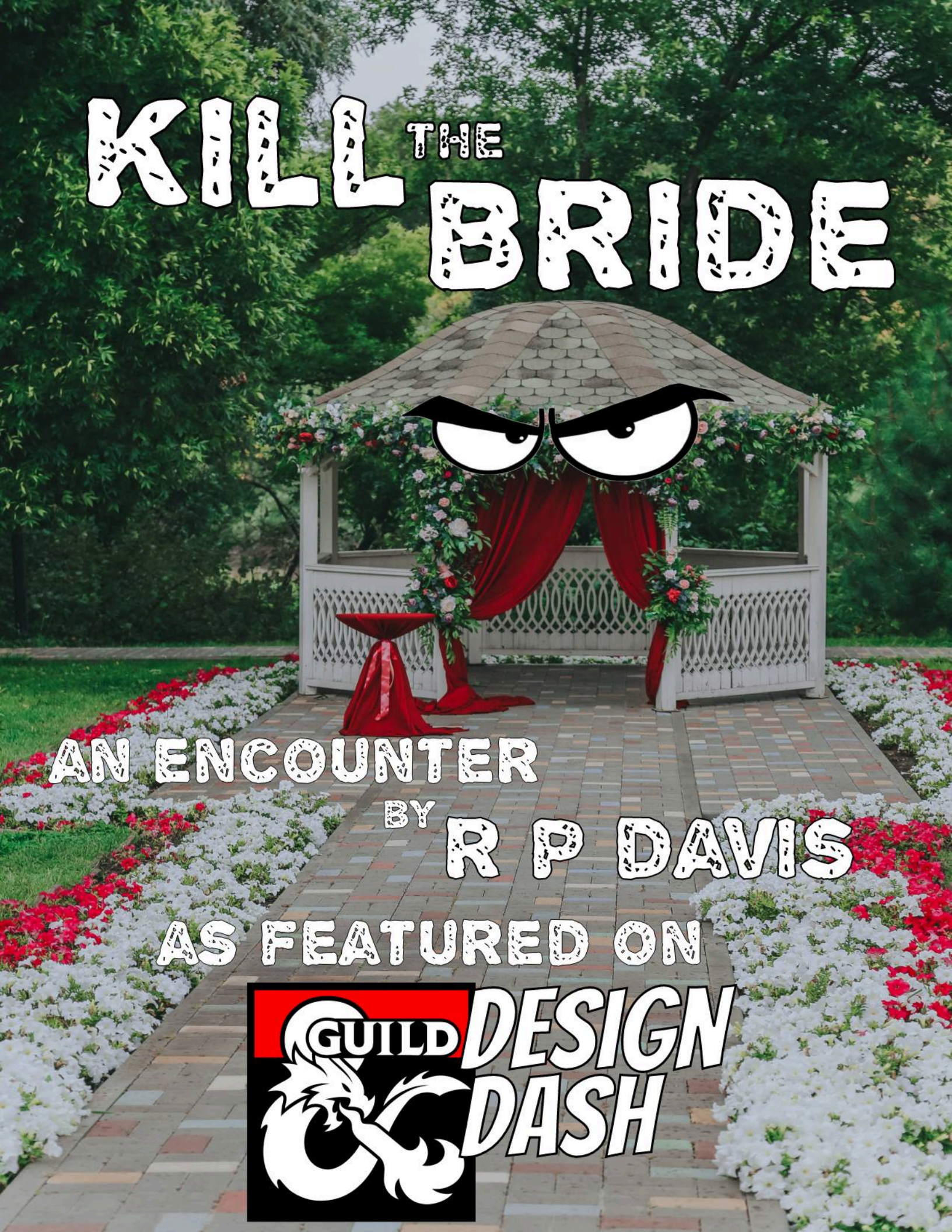
KILL THE BRIDE



AN ENCOUNTER

BY

R P DAVIS

AS FEATURED ON

GUILD DESIGN DASH

Kill the Bride

An Encounter for Fifth Edition

As Featured on

Dungeon Masters Guild Design Dash, the most chaotic (only?) fifth edition D&D design game show out there!

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=R1zAzFqIDfs

Introduction

It was an honor to appear on Design Dash alongside such awesome people. We had a great deal of fun, as you'll see when you watch the video. I hope this encounter is as much fun for you and your players as it was for me to create!

Notes: Links to relevant monster stat blocks lead to https://5thsrd.org/ for your convenience. A stat block for the new monster (the **dread gazebo**) is at the end of the document.

The Details

In the spring, it's traditional for the devoted worshipers of Lathander to celebrate their nuptials. In the North Ward of Waterdeep is a park, a green and pleasant place, often rented by couples wishing to wed.

This morning it's the turn of Mabon Pritchard and Owena Parcells to tie the knot. They've hired the park's central gazebo as the focus of their ceremony, and invited at least 200 people to share their joy.

There's catering off to one side under a pavilion, along with a string quartet and a dancing-master (the Parcells are wealthy merchants).

Unknown to them, Owena's jealous ex, Eshud Clawdew, is crashing the party. Eshud has spent a dragon's fortune with the Zhents to acquire a whacking great pile of magic (including spell scrolls and other magic items), hid the pile under the gazebo, and enchanted it with a special string of commands. His intent is to blow the gazebo (and the wedding party) all the way to Thay.

When the priest says, "Should anyone present know of any reason that this couple should not be joined in holy matrimony, speak now or forever hold your peace", Eshud stands up and shouts, "YES! If they **do** wed, I'll blow this whole place all the way to Neverwinter!"

If the wedding goes forward, Eshud cackles madly and speaks the string of command words. But the magic doesn't go BOOM like he'd planned — it animates the gazebo into a **dread gazebo**.

Yeah, it's a gigantic mimic. It rampages through the park, trampling and devouring people.

Preventing the Encounter

Spot the Magic. A character proficient in Arcana senses a near-critical mass of magic under the gazebo. Additionally, characters with a passive Perception of 16 or higher notice the lattice covering the posts supporting the gazebo have recently been removed and replaced.

Spot the Villain. A character with a passive Perception of 14 or higher who can see Eshud Clawde notices the half-elf is sweating profusely. Characters with a passive

Perception of 16 or higher notice Eshud gazes intently at the happy couple, but the half-elf's eyes periodically flicker to the park's exit.

Confront the Villain. The characters may decide to confront Eshud before he activates the magic.

If the characters confront him before he stands up to object, Eshud denies any ill will or malfeasance. A character with a passive Insight of 12 or higher can see he's not telling the whole truth. A passive Insight of 16 or higher reveals Eshud is clearly lying, and notices (from his eyes constantly flicking to the gazebo) his special interest in the gazebo. A successful DC 14 Intimidation or Persuasion check (let the players' proposed actions inform which ability score to use) frightens or convinces Eshud into spilling the beans about his plan.

If the characters confront Eshud in mid-protest, the Intimidation/Persuasion check DC increases to 18.

Either way, if he doesn't trigger the transformation, Eshud sits down, covers his face with his hands, and bursts into tears.

Running the Encounter

The **Win Condition** is simple: Don't let the wedding party (or too many guests) get killed. If the heroes don't leap to help, or start indiscriminately chucking *fireballs*, Cenver Hunabar, an impeccably-dressed nobleman, berates them and tells them what to do.

Roll Initiative. When the **dread gazebo** animates, the heckin' doody hits the fan. The gazebo gets a free attack against the wedding party (two **nobles** and a **priest**), because they're literally in its mouth already.

Otherwise it uses its Trampling Charge attack as often as possible to run roughshod over the immediate area.

Features of the Area. Here are the highlights:

- Bright summer sunlight over an open field, 100 by 200 feet.
- The gazebo starts at the narrow eastern end of the field. The northern long side has marquee tents sheltering the catering.
- Guests and servants run about screaming, smacking headlong into each other and turning the whole area into difficult terrain.

Adjusting the Encounter. If the characters have too easy a time, the catering tables and cutlery animate, too: add one **animated armor** per character to increase the challenge. If the characters look like they're about to get themselves and/or everyone else killed, reinforcements from the Watchful Order of Magists and Protectors (2 **mages**) teleport in using one of Waterdeep's many magic portals.



Concluding the Encounter

There are a variety of ways the encounter can end.

Total Success. If the heroes prevent the encounter entirely, award XP as though they slew the gazebo. The happy couple reward them with 500 gp each and their pick of the Honkin' Pile o' Magic under the gazebo (it's up to you to decide what's there; this is a great opportunity to give each player something they *really* want for their character). The heroes' tact and expertise attract other members of the newlyweds' families, who discreetly offer certain 'little jobs' the heroes might find interesting—or lucrative.

Success. If the heroes fail to prevent the encounter but kill the gazebo, award XP for killing the vile thing. If they save the happy couple, the newlyweds give each hero 500 gp. If the heroes are interested, the couple (and their families) may have other 'little jobs' for the heroes to handle. Other rewards are as follows:

Failure. If they fail to prevent the happy couple from being killed, they get nothing but "thanks for trying" from the victims' families.

Total Failure. If everyone dies, nobody gets XP except the gazebo, which smashes its way down toward Undermountain. Halaster is delighted to have a new pet.

Special Note. Animating the gazebo consumed everything valuable in the Honkin' Pile o' Magic.

Dread Gazebo

Huge aberration (shapechanger), neutral

Armor Class 14 (natural armor)
Hit Points 103 (9d12 + 45)
Speed 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	8 (-1)	20 (+5)	7 (-2)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)

Saving Throws Str +8, Con +8
Skills Athletics +8
Damage Vulnerabilities fire
Damage Resistances piercing
Damage Immunities psychic
Condition Immunities blinded, charmed, prone, unconscious
Senses blindsight 60 ft. (blind beyond this radius), tremorsense 120 ft., passive Perception 12
Languages —
Challenge 8 (3,900 XP)

False Appearance (Object Form Only). While the Dread Gazebo remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ordinary gazebo.

Grappler. The Dread Gazebo has advantage on attack rolls against any creature grappled by it.

Actions

Multiattack. The Dread Gazebo makes two Munch attacks.

Munch. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. *Hit:* 14 (2d8 + 5) bludgeoning damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 13). Until this grapple ends, the target is restrained. The Dread Gazebo can have up to 3 Medium or smaller targets grappled at one time.

Swallow. The Dread Gazebo makes one Munch attack against a Medium or smaller target it is grappling. If the attack hits, the target is swallowed, and the grapple ends. The swallowed target is blinded and restrained, it has total cover against attacks and other effects outside the Dread Gazebo, and it takes 8 (2d8) bludgeoning damage at the start of each of the Dread Gazebo's turns. The Dread Gazebo can have up to 3 targets swallowed at a time. If the Dread Gazebo dies, a swallowed creature is no longer restrained by it and can escape from the corpse using 5 feet of movement, exiting prone.

Trampling Charge (Recharge 5–6). The Dread Gazebo moves its full speed in a straight line. Each Medium or smaller creature in its path must make a DC 13 Strength saving throw. On a failure, a creature takes 16 (4d8) bludgeoning damage and is knocked prone. On a success, a creature takes half as much damage and isn't knocked prone.

About the Author

R P Davis is an Adamantine Best-Selling DMs Guild creator and RPG industry freelancer who's worked for Kobold Press, Cubicle 7, Wizards of the Coast, and a bunch of other publishers. He's the Chief Kabouter at Kabouter Games.

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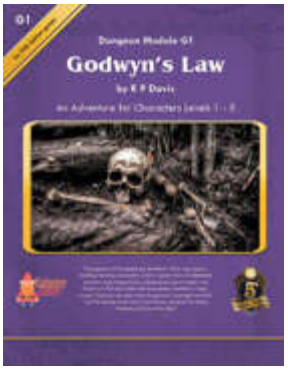
















...and many many more!

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